PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Dodge Ramcharger (1981–1993)

1981–1993 · AW100 · AW150 · AD150 · Canyon Sport

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust in the rockers, floors and body mounts**
  On RamCharger Central, owners list the rockers (especially just ahead of the rear wheels), the front floors, the wheel lips, the rear quarters, the drip rail and the body-mount crossmembers. One member says flaky or feathered metal there is always worse once you strip it, and another says that if the very rear body crossmember is good, everything else is fixable. Check the frame around brackets and crossmembers too.

- [ ] **Make it go into 4WD**
  On 1985–93 trucks, shift into 4WD High on the test drive and make sure the front axle actually drives. The CAD system depends on engine vacuum, a switch on the transfer case and a vacuum motor on the axle, and trucks that haven't used 4WD for years often have a sticky collar. If someone has fitted manual hubs, ask whether the CAD was locked, because hubs alone won't fix it.

- [ ] **Steering slop**
  Owners say the coupler where the steering shaft meets the steering box is known for wearing loose. A rebuild only returns it to original condition, so most fit an aftermarket shaft with needle-bearing U-joints. Have someone rock the wheel while you watch the coupler, the drag link and the tie-rod ends. Loose ball joints and worn U-joints turn up regularly too.

- [ ] **The 9.25 clunk**
  Many second-generation trucks clunk when shifted into Drive or Reverse. One member's diagnosis is that the pinion has lost preload and worn its bearings. Pull on the pinion yoke with the driveshaft off: it shouldn't move in and out. Worn spider gears, U-joints, slip-yoke splines and slack ring-and-pinion backlash all add to it, so a clunk can be a cheap fix or a full rear rebuild.

- [ ] **Liftgate cracks and hatch fit**
  RamCharger Central members list cracks in the fiberglass liftgate around the hinges as a common problem, alongside sagging door hinges. Open and close the hatch, check the glass and seals, and look for water in the cargo area. On 1990 and later trucks with the electric rear defroster, check that it works.

- [ ] **Overdrive automatic health**
  Four-speed overdrive automatics arrived around 1990, and owners say the overdrive is the weak point if it overheats under load or with big tires. Drive it hard enough to get a full set of shifts and a kickdown, check that the fluid isn't dark or burnt, and look for an auxiliary cooler. Trucks with the three-speed TorqueFlite or the NP435 four-speed have less to worry about.

- [ ] **Engine and fuel system**
  On carbureted mid-1980s trucks, find out whether the Lean Burn / Spark Control Computer (behind the battery in the inner fender) is still fitted. Owners say it will eventually give trouble and is often converted to plain electronic ignition. TBI trucks need working sensors and a service manual for diagnosis. Magnums are prone to vacuum leaks from blown valley-pan gaskets, and owners report cracked heads in some years.

- [ ] **Vents, vacuum and wiring**
  If the vents are stuck on defrost or won't change direction, the HVAC vacuum harness is usually to blame. One owner warns that the air box under the dash can fill with leaves and become a fire risk. Check the wiring and the fusible links on the driver's inner fender, and make sure every gauge works. Power window motors and locks are frequent failures.

YEARS TO KNOW

1981–1984	SWEET SPOT	The only second-generation trucks with a conventional, non-CAD front axle. A long-time RamCharger Central member names them as one of the two best ranges to buy
1982–1985	RECALL	Recalls: 82V055000 front ball-joint clamp bolts (1982), 82V095000 ignition switch (1983), 84V047000 master cylinder seal (1984), 84V117000 twisted front brake hose (1985) and 84V115000 rear step bumper / fuel system (1980–85)
1988	SWEET SPOT	Throttle-body fuel injection on the 318 (170 hp). NP241 replaces the NP208. Owners recommend 1988–93 trucks for fuel injection, which also copes better with steep off-road angles
1992	SWEET SPOT	5.2 Magnum with multi-port injection (230 hp) becomes the standard engine, with the 360 TBI optional. Canyon Sport package offered. RamCharger Central members name 1992–93 as the years to buy for the Magnum engines
1993	SWEET SPOT	5.9 Magnum (230 hp, 325 lb-ft). Dodge lists only the four-speed overdrive automatic. Trims S, S-Plus, Base, LE and Canyon Sport (about 200 Canyon Sports). Last US model year

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Rear step bumper may not protect the fuel system in a rear impact**
  1981–1985 (also 1980) · NHTSA 84V115000
- [ ] **Cracked front ball-joint clamp bolts**
  1982 · NHTSA 82V055000
- [ ] **Ignition switch contact carrier can crack**
  1983 · NHTSA 82V095000
- [ ] **Master cylinder seal leak**
  1984 · NHTSA 84V047000
- [ ] **Twisted front brake hose**
  1985 · NHTSA 84V117000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN**
  The 10th character is the model year: D for 1983, F for 1985, H for 1987, J for 1988, K for 1989, N for 1992 and P for 1993, as on the trucks sold on BaT. The first character shows where it was built. Warren Truck in Michigan built Ramchargers through 1985, and the 1983 and 1985 trucks we checked start 1B4, while the late-1980s and 1990s trucks start 3B4, the Mexican-assembly prefix.
- [ ] **Year by the grille**
  Egg-crate grille through 1985, the crosshair grille with rectangular headlamps for 1986–90, and a revised grille for 1991–93. Panels interchange across many years, so check the grille against the VIN.

- [ ] **Front axle**
  A 1981–84 4×4 has a conventional open-knuckle Dana 44 with locking hubs. From 1985 the CAD axle has a hump on the long side of the axle tube (the driver's side on these trucks) with a vacuum motor, two vacuum lines and a 4WD indicator switch. If a 1985–93 truck has manual hubs, the CAD may have been locked or converted.

- [ ] **Transfer case**
  Torque King lists the NP208 for 1980–87 Ramchargers and the NP241D for 1988–93. Both are aluminum chain-drive part-time cases. On CAD trucks, a vacuum switch threads into the top of the case above the shift lever.

- [ ] **Engine**
  1981–87 trucks have carburetors. 1988–91 TBI engines have a twin-injector throttle body on a cast-iron intake. Magnum engines (5.2 from 1992, 5.9 for 1993) have the tall 'beer keg' intake with a fuel rail and eight injectors. The 5.9 Magnum was only offered in a Ramcharger for 1993.

- [ ] **Canyon Sport**
  Dodge's 1993 brochure lists a body-color grille, Light Sand Metallic lower paint and bumpers, an upper tape stripe and cast aluminum wheels. The upper colors were Black, Bright White, Flame Red or Emerald Green. A Magnum V8, automatic transmission, heavy-duty transfer case and outlined-white-letter tires were standard on the 4×4. Paint and tape are easy to copy, so check the build details.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/ramcharger/ramcharger-2nd/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks